

THIS

If I could at last tell you what is in me,
if I could shout: people! I have lied by pretending it was not there,
It was there, day and night.

Only thus was I able to describe your inflammable cities,
Brief loves, games disintegrating into dust,
earrings, a strap falling lightly from a shoulder,
scenes in bedrooms and on battlefields.

Writing has been for me a protective strategy
Of erasing traces. No one likes
A man who reaches for the forbidden.

I asked help of rivers in which I used to swim, lakes
With a footbridge over the rushes, a valley
Where an echo of singing had twilight for its companion.
And I confess my ecstatic praise of being
Might just have been exercises in the high style.
Underneath was this, which I do not attempt to name.

This. Which is like the thoughts of a homeless man walking in an alien
city in freezing weather.

And like the moment when a tracked-down Jew glimpses the heavy
helmets of the German police approaching.

The moment when the crown prince goes for the first time down to the
city and sees the truth of the world: misery, sickness, age, and death.

Or the immobile face of someone who has just understood that he's
been abandoned forever.

Or the irrevocable verdict of the doctor.

This. Which signifies knocking against a stone wall and knowing that the wall will not yield to any imploration.

TO A HAZEL TREE

You do not recognize me, but it's me all the same,
The one who used to make my bows by cutting your brown
branches,
So straight and so swift in their reaching for the sun.
You grew large, your shade is huge, you send up new shoots.
It's a pity I'm not a boy anymore.
Now I could cut for myself only a stick, for, as you see, I walk with a
cane.

I loved your brown bark with its whitish tinge, its true hazel color.
I'm glad that some oaks and ashes have survived,
But I rejoice at seeing you, magical as always, with the pearls of your
nuts
With the generations of squirrels that have danced in you.

This is something of a Heraclitean meditation: I stand here
Remembering my bygone self and life as it was but also as it could
have been.
Nothing lasts, but everything lasts: a great stability,
And I try to locate my destiny in it.
Which, in truth, I did not want to accept.
I was happy with my bow, stalking at the edge of a fairy tale.
What happened to me later deserves no more than a shrug;
It is only biography, i.e., fiction.

POSTSCRIPTUM

Biography or fiction or a long dream.

Layers of white clouds on a fragment of sky between the brightness of
the birches.

CZESLAW MILOSZ



New and Collected Poems 1931-2001



An Imprint of HarperCollinsPublishers

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information address HarperCollins Publishers, Inc., 10 East
53rd Street, New York, NY 10022.

"Road-side Dog," "Pelicans," "A Ball," "Watering Can,"
"From My Dentist's Window," "Autumn," "Helene," "Helene's
Religion," "Yokimura," "America," "Christopher Robin," and
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write: Special Markets Department, HarperCollins Publishers,
Inc., 10 East 53rd Street, New York, NY 10022.

First Ecco paperback edition 2003

Designed by Kate Nichols

Library of Congress Cataloging-in-Publication Data has been
applied for.

ISBN 0-06-019667-X (hardcover)

ISBN 0-06-051448-5 (pbk.)

05 06 07 DC/RRD 10 9 8 7 6 5 4

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